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California Bans 4 Food Additives, Including 2 Linked to Cancer

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(HealthDay News) — California has become the first state to ban 4 ingredients that are commonly added to food and have been linked to cancer and other health issues, NBC News reported.

The additives are red dye No. 3 (used to color foods and medicines), potassium bromate (added to flour to help bread rise), brominated vegetable oil (an emulsifier used in citrus drinks), and propylparaben (a preservative).

Red dye No. 3 and potassium bromate have both been linked to cancer in lab animals. Brominated vegetable oil has been tied to behavioral and reproductive issues in lab animals, and propylparaben is believed to mimic estrogen and may act as an endocrine disruptor.

The new law, signed by Gov. Gavin Newsom, bans the additives in California, but they could be removed from products across the country. Assembly member Jesse Gabriel said the law will not eliminate the foods the additives typically go in — which range from orange soda to hamburger rolls and candies — but the manufacturers will need to make “really minor” changes to ingredients.

The law will go into effect in 2027. This gives brands time to revise recipes and “establishes national updated safety levels for these additives” until the US Food and Drug Administration makes changes, Newsom said.

The National Confectioners Association, a trade association for candy makers, spoke out against the bill. “Governor Newsom’s approval of this bill will undermine consumer confidence and create confusion around food safety,” the group said in a statement. “This law replaces a uniform national food safety system with a patchwork of inconsistent state requirements created by legislative fiat that will increase food costs.”

NBC News Article

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